The History and Process of Voting

Source: Ben's Guide to the U.S. Government

Any U.S. citizen who is at least 18 years old, and who meets certain requirements, can vote in federal elections. This has not always been the case. When the United States first won its independence, there were restrictions on who could vote. In some states, only white male landowners that were at least 21 years old could vote. Beginning in 1870, a series of Constitutional Amendments and other laws have extended voting privileges to more and more citizens.

- The Fifteenth Amendment (Amendment XV) was ratified (or officially adopted) on February 3, 1870. It gave African-American men the right to vote by declaring that the "right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any state on account of race, color, or previous condition of servitude."

- The Nineteenth Amendment (Amendment XIX) was ratified on August 18, 1920. It guarantees the right to vote to all American women by declaring that "the right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of sex."

- The Voting Rights Act of 1965 (Public Law 89-110) became effective on August 6, 1965. It enforced the Fifteenth Amendment and outlawed discriminatory voting practices.

- The Twenty-sixth Amendment (Amendment XXVI) was ratified on July 1, 1971. It lowered the voting age from 21 to 18 and declared that "the right of citizens of the United States, who are eighteen years of age or older, to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of age."

It took a long time and a lot of hard work to extend the right to vote to every adult citizen in the United States. That's why it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote. In order to vote, you must first be registered. Requirements for registration and registration deadlines change depending on where you live in the U.S.

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Registration forms can be obtained from local election officials in your county, from your state's election office, or through voting advocacy groups. You can also register to vote at motor vehicle or driver's licensing offices, Armed Forces recruitment offices, or state agencies that provide public assistance services. Many states offer registration opportunities at public libraries, public high schools and universities, and post offices.

The National Mail Voter Registration Form from the United States Election Assistance Commission (EAC) allows you to register to vote from anywhere in the United States. The forms on the EAC site have specific information in several languages about voter registration for each state. Can you find the instructions for your state?

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Name: _____ Date: _____

1. Who can vote in Federal elections?

A any U.S. citizen who is at least 18 years old and meets certain requirements
B any U.S. resident who is at least 18 years old and meets certain requirements
C any U.S. citizen who is at least 16 years old and meets certain requirements
D any U.S. resident who is at least 16 years old and meets certain requirements

2. The text discusses the extension of voting rights in the United States. What was the sequence of their extension?

A Voting rights were given to all American women, then to African-American men, and then to citizens of the United States who are 18 years of age or older.
B Voting rights were given to all American women, then to citizens of the United States who are 18 years of age or older, and then to African-American men.
C Voting rights were given to African-American men, then to all American women, and then to citizens of the United States who are 18 years of age or older.
D Voting rights were given to African-American men, then to citizens of the United States who are 18 years of age or older, and then to all American women.

3. Read these sentences from the text: "When the United States first won its independence, there were restrictions on who could vote. In some states, only white male landowners that were at least 21 years old could vote. Beginning in 1870, a series of Constitutional Amendments and other laws have extended voting privileges to more and more citizens."

What evidence in the text supports the statement that "a series of Constitutional Amendments and other laws have extended voting privileges to more and more citizens"?

A Requirements for voter registration and registration deadlines change depending on where you live in the U.S.
B You can register to vote at motor vehicle or driver's licensing offices and Armed Forces recruitment offices.
C The National Mail Voter Registration Form from the United States Election Assistance Commission allows you to register to vote from anywhere in the United States.
D The Nineteenth Amendment, ratified in 1920, guaranteed the right to vote to all American women.

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4. Read these sentences from the text: "The Voting Rights Act of 1965 (Public Law 89-110) became effective on August 6, 1965. It enforced the Fifteenth Amendment and outlawed discriminatory voting practices."

Based on this information, what can you infer about the Fifteenth Amendment before the Voting Rights Act?

A The Fifteenth Amendment was popular with a lot of U.S. citizens who were under the age of 21.
B The Fifteenth Amendment was unpopular with a lot of U.S. citizens who were under the age of 21.
C The Fifteenth Amendment was not being completely obeyed.
D The Fifteenth Amendment was being completely obeyed.

5. What is a main idea of this text?

A The Twenty-sixth Amendment, ratified in 1971, lowered the voting age from 21 to 18.
B The right to vote in the United States was slowly extended to more and more citizens.
C Many states offer voter registration opportunities at public libraries and post offices.
D When the United States was founded, only white male landowners that were at least 21 years old could vote in some states.

6. Read these sentences from the text: "It took a long time and a lot of hard work to extend the right to vote to every adult citizen in the United States. That's why **it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote**."

What does the author probably mean by writing that "**it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote**"?

A It is the responsibility of every American citizen who can vote to vote.
B It is the responsibility of every American who works for the government to vote.
C It is the responsibility of all American voters to respect each other.
D It is the responsibility of all American voters to think carefully when they are voting.

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7. Read these sentences from the text: "It took a long time and a lot of hard work to extend the right to vote to every adult citizen in the United States. That's why it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote."

How could the second sentence be rewritten without changing its meaning?

A Currently, it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote.
B Specifically, it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote.
C Instead, it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote.
D Therefore, it is every eligible American citizen's responsibility to vote.

8. Read this statement from the text: "It took a long time . . . to extend the right to vote to every adult citizen in the United States."

What evidence in the text supports this statement?

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_____

_____

9. Why does the author believe "it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote"?

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10. Argue for or against the author's claim that "it is every eligible American citizen's civic responsibility to vote." Support your argument with evidence from the text.

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